

Assimilated

THE COVER STORY THIS MONTH looks at how we may already be like the alien species called the Borg from Star Trek. I won't go into details here, because it's well covered in the articles that make up the cover story, but there is one large supposition we make here in the cover theme, and that is to treat technology use as a cybernetic enhancement of humans. This is different to the traditional meaning of a cyborg, and we have good reason for doing so. I'll try and explain why in this column.

Yes, it's true that the word cyborg itself comes from the shortening of the two words, cybernetic and organism, which essentially means a sort of amalgamation of cybernetic parts and organic parts to make a hybrid entity. Many would consider someone with a pacemaker to keep their heart going to be a cyborg, while others would insist on it not being merely a medical tool, but would need to enhance an organism in a way that gave it abilities that make the specimen better than other members of its species in some way. Sort of like a human getting super vision – the ability to see as well as a hawk. Now that would be something everyone would agree is a cyborg, right?

In short, some believe that you'd have to be able to give a specimen enhanced capabilities to consider it a cybernetic organism (cyborg).

I agree, to a great degree. I certainly believe that to earn the title of a cyborg, a specimen needs to gain enhanced capabilities. I keep saying specimen because a cyborg doesn't have to be human, it just needs to be a cross between technology and biology... of any species.

However, I don't believe that the technology needs to be physically attached or somehow woven into the biology of a specimen for it to qualify as a cyborg. I honestly don't see how a chip embedded in your brain which gives you access to the internet is accepted as you becoming a cyborg, whereas a device you carry with you and access whenever you want to achieve the same goal does not qualify you to be one. It just doesn't add up logically.

After all, whether it is a billion neurons or your entire central nervous system interfacing with a chip directly in order to send a signal to your brain, or your eyes seeing something and then translating that as a signal to your brain, they are

basically identical outcomes. You gain something you had no power to discover on your own – even if it's just another funny cat video on the internet, it's something you could not experience, because you could not have been there to witness it yourself.

Still, in order to steer clear of the cyborg argument that might crop up because of different definitions, we found a loophole and equated all of us technology savvy individuals to The Borg. This is not the same as saying we're cyborgs, it's merely equating us to a fictional species... who were essentially cyborgs... ;-)

See what we did there? That sleight of hand (or rather words), allows us to delve into some very complex ideas, and even explore whether or not it's a good thing that we are either already like, or fast becoming like, The Borg.

Personally, I'm of the opinion that it's a good thing, because while we may be becoming the Borg, or even cyborgs, as long as we don't lose our humanity while doing so, we will be fine. As long as we ensure that the technology is under our control, and not the other way around, technology really will help us perfect our imperfect selves.

In fact, we've already been assimilated, and geeks like you who love technology, are far more a part of the collective than the average Joe. The real challenge is to remain cyborgs and not totally become like the Borg collective. Retaining our individuality will be the key to ensuring that our humanity stays intact. Whether or not we will manage, or whether we will actually become a hive mind... that's something our grandchildren will find out. We will be long dead when it happens, but what we do today will be key in deciding what our kids inherit.

What do you think? Is resistance futile against the technology juggernaut, or is there hope that we can resist just enough to prevent being totally assimilated? Read the cover story and then write in to me to let me know your thoughts... 



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